

## National income inequality predicts cultural variation in mouth to mouth kissing<sup>1</sup>

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### Research question

Romantic kissing is a well-known custom but is not observed across all known cultures<sup>2</sup>. If it plays a role in 'assessing' a partner (e.g. their health) and/or maintaining a long-term (investing) relationship<sup>3-4</sup>, national attitudes and behaviours related to kissing should vary according to the health or wealth of a nation (e.g. if health/long-term investment is of greater concern in some environments than others<sup>5-7</sup>)



### Results and conclusions

Kissing was valued more in established relationships than during courtship. Preliminary evidence suggested that people hug their partner more in poorer/healthier nations.

**As predicted, people in countries of high income inequality kiss their partner more often than people in areas of low income inequality**

**There are two components to a good kiss – 'technique, contact and arousal' and 'sensory factors'. Sensory factors are more important to women than men and pleasantness of breath is the most important item within this factor**

### Method

Participants (13 nations, 6 continents) completed a questionnaire on French kissing, examining attitudes (importance at two relationship stages and satisfaction with amount of kissing), frequency, and the importance of seven items when deciding if someone is a 'good kisser'<sup>3-4</sup>. We posed similar questions for hugging/cuddling (without kissing) and sex. Responses were compared against measures of national health<sup>8</sup> and wealth (GDP and GINI)

